

Recognize it

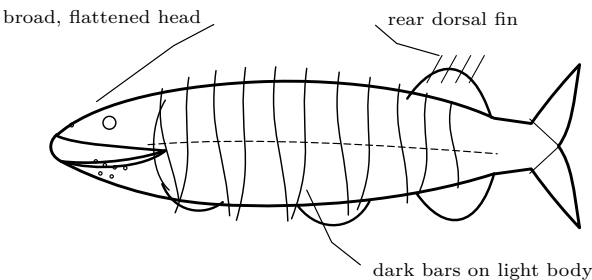
Long esocid usually with dark bars or spots on a light body and pointed tail lobes.

Body	Lower cheek and lower gill cover largely unscaled; six to nine jaw pores per side.
Mouth/fins	Duckbill snout with large teeth; fins set far back.
Confusion	Northern pike usually has light spots on dark body, rounded tail lobes, and five jaw pores.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Large structural edges, weedlines, points, open-water prey, and connected movement routes.
Food and season
Large fish prey; location follows forage and suitable temperature more than shoreline convenience.

Identification plate



Find it on these waters

Pine	Treat deep weed and basin transitions as search water only where current evidence supports presence.
North	No authoritative current presence evidence was found. Do not infer presence from a regulation or target muskellunge without current survey evidence.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Large moving bait.** Search edges with tackle able to cast, land, and release the fish without exhaustion.
- 2. **Sucker quick-strike rig.** Where lawful, use two hooks designed for an immediate set; never allow swallowing.
- 3. **Stop rule.** Warm water, missing release tools, or fatigue ends the attempt. A follow is evidence; change angle before bait.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Use a large coated cradle/net, long pliers and cutters. Keep fish in water, support level, and cut hooks rather than wrestle.

Water-specific rule	May 2–Dec 31, 2026 open water; 40-in minimum; daily bag 1 on both lake pages. Verify connected-water exceptions.
Kitchen choice	Harvest is legal only at the controlling minimum; conservation and mercury make release the usual choice.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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